
48 exercises / instructions

THREE KINDS OF QUESTION

Questions 1-24 test opening recall, 25-36 test plans and defense, and 37-48 compare concrete candidates from the laboratories. These are not all tactical puzzles and do not all have one uniquely best move.

WORK WITHOUT THE ANSWER

Use a board and write your answer. Spend two to five minutes on a recall question and five to ten on a candidate comparison. Name the opponent's threat before choosing your own move.

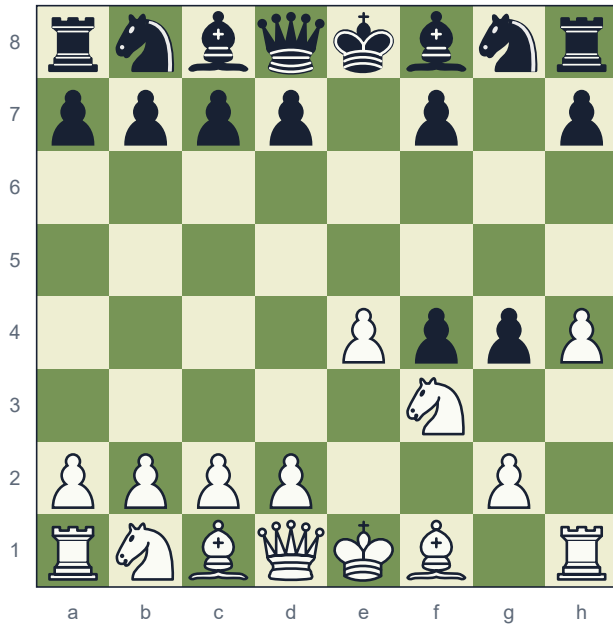
MARKING

Award one point for a legal, relevant choice or plan; one for a clear reason; one for recognizing the opponent's resource; and one for a supporting variation or accurate description of the structure. Maximum: 192. Do not reward memorized notation that you cannot explain.

ANSWERS ARE LATER

The question pages come first, followed by explained answers and sample continuations. In planning questions the sample answer is a guide, not an exhaustive list of reasonable plans.

Exercises 1-2



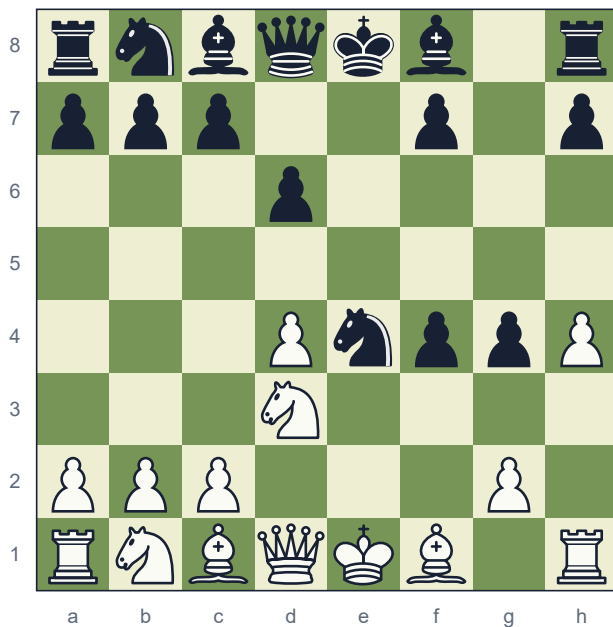
01 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



02 / OPENING RECALL

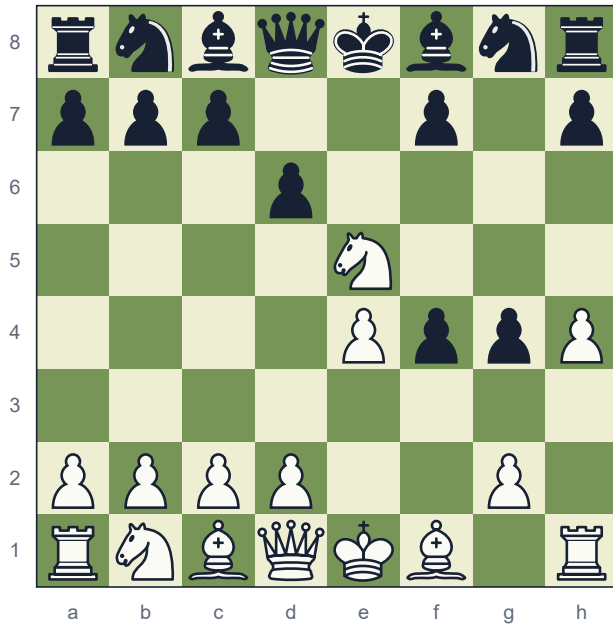
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 3-4



White to move

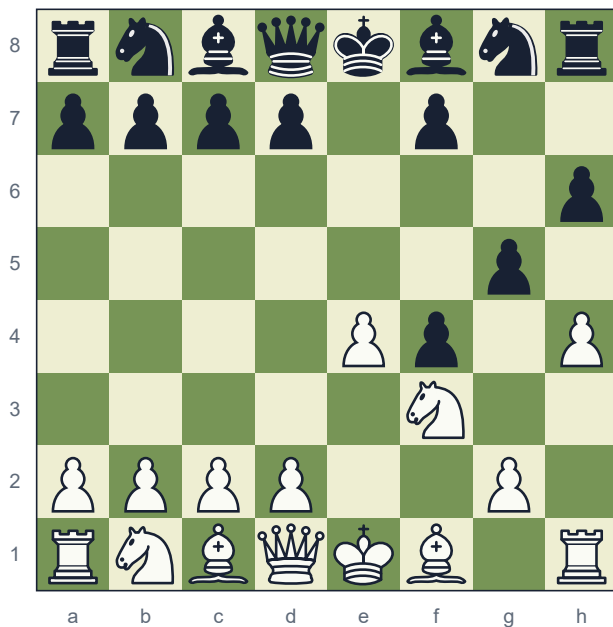
03 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

04 / OPENING RECALL

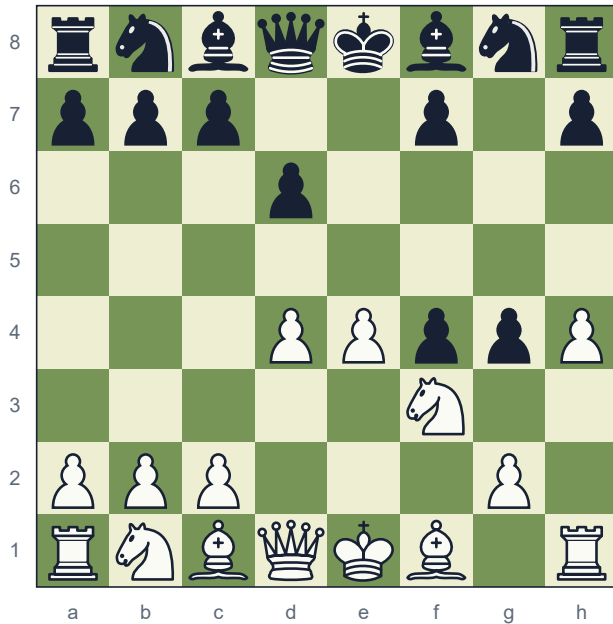
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 5-6



White to move

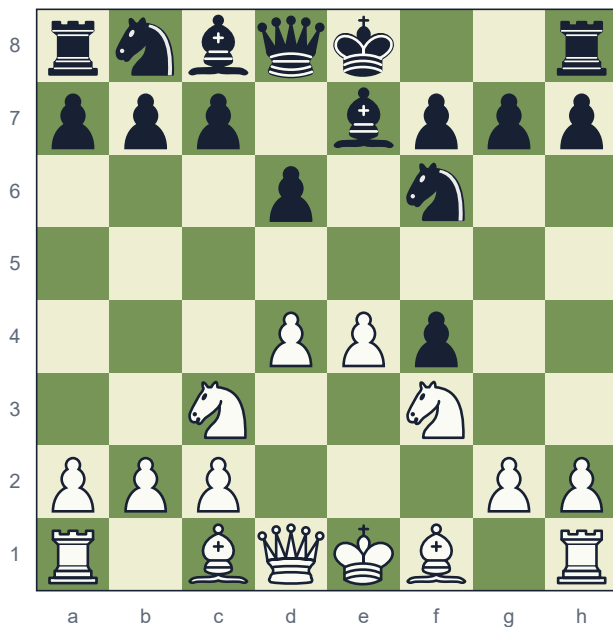
05 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

06 / OPENING RECALL

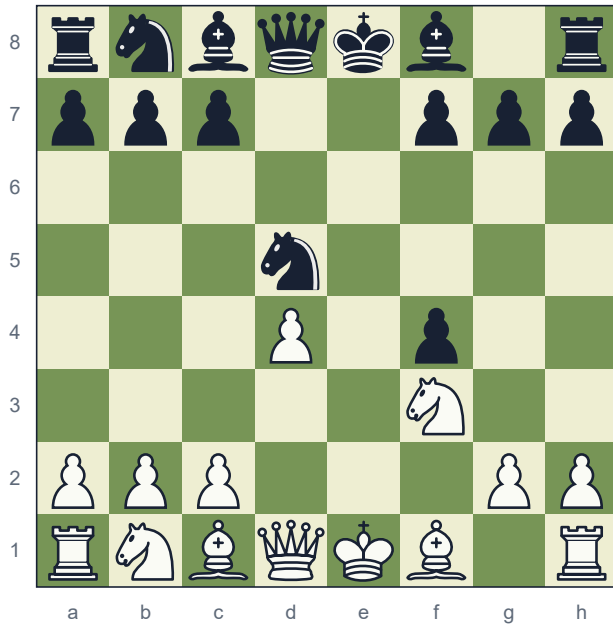
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 7-8



White to move

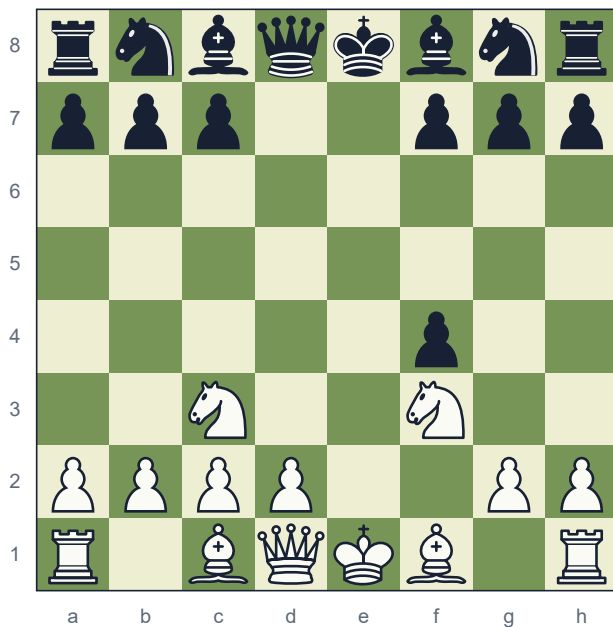
07 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

08 / OPENING RECALL

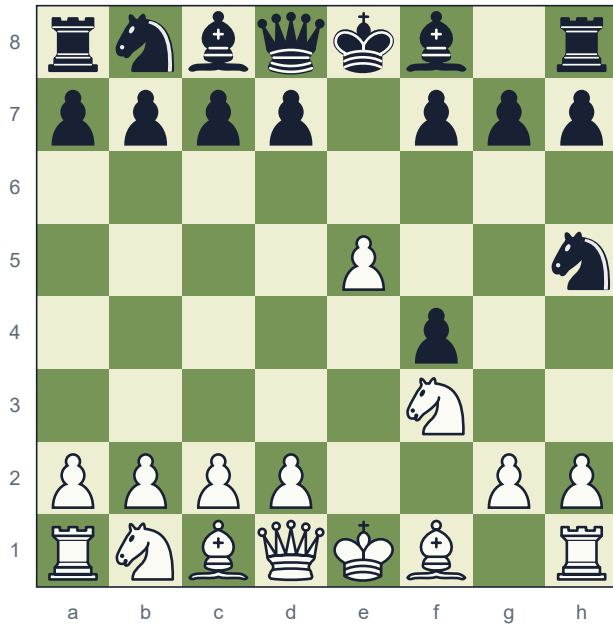
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 9-10



White to move

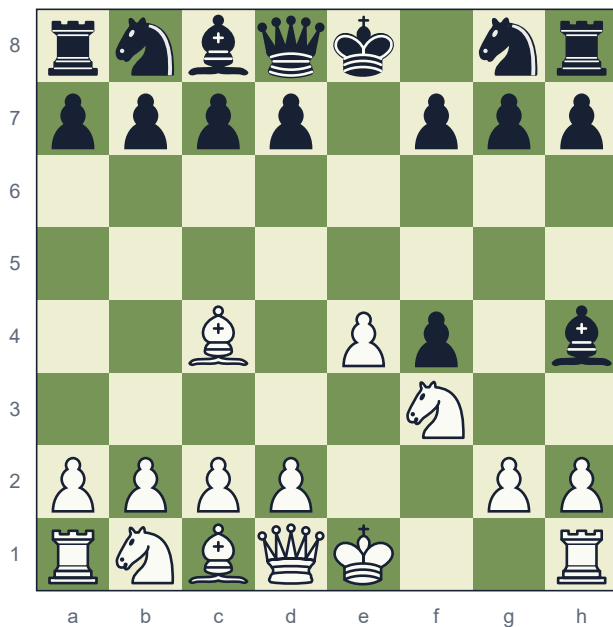
09 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move - in check

10 / OPENING RECALL

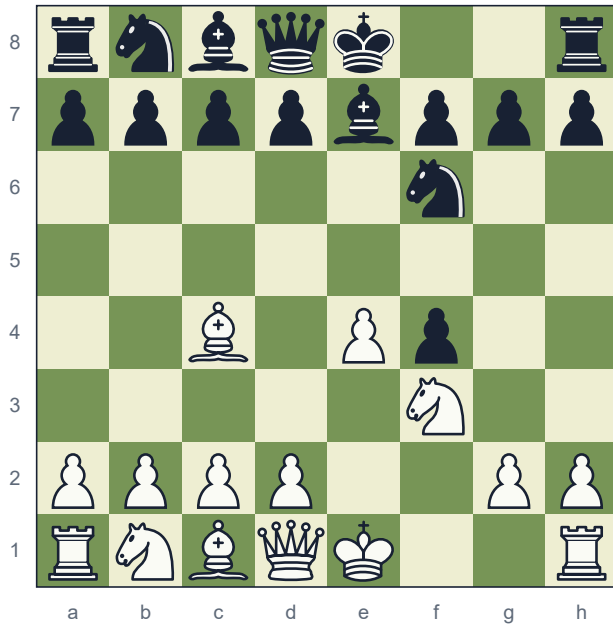
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 11-12



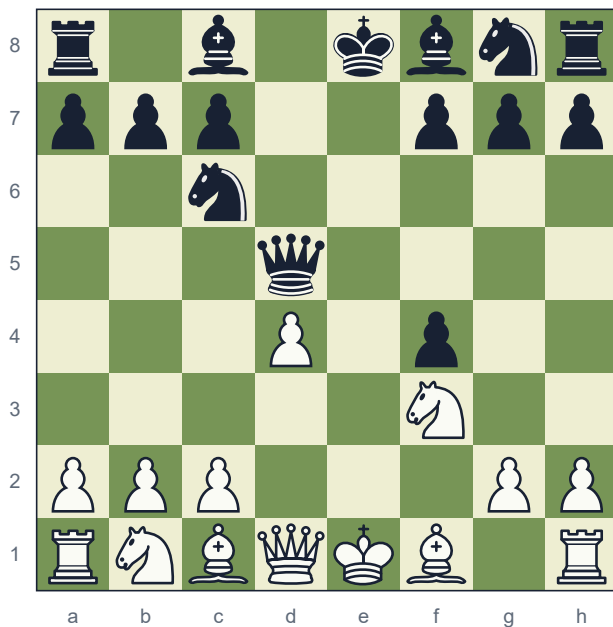
11 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



12 / OPENING RECALL

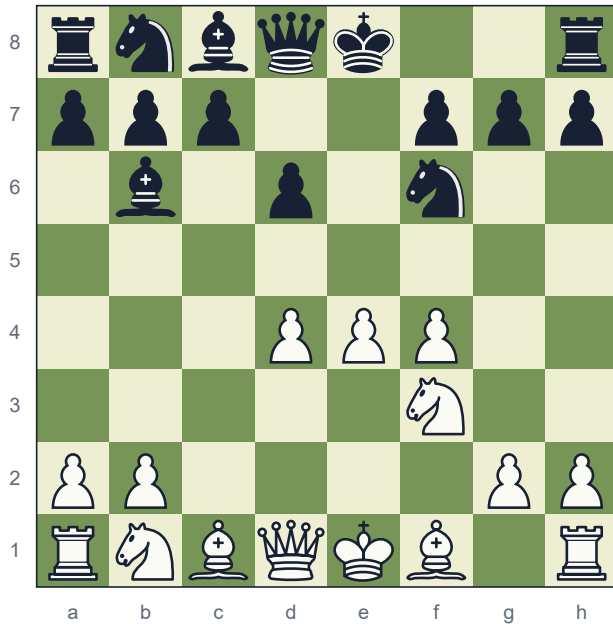
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 13-14



White to move

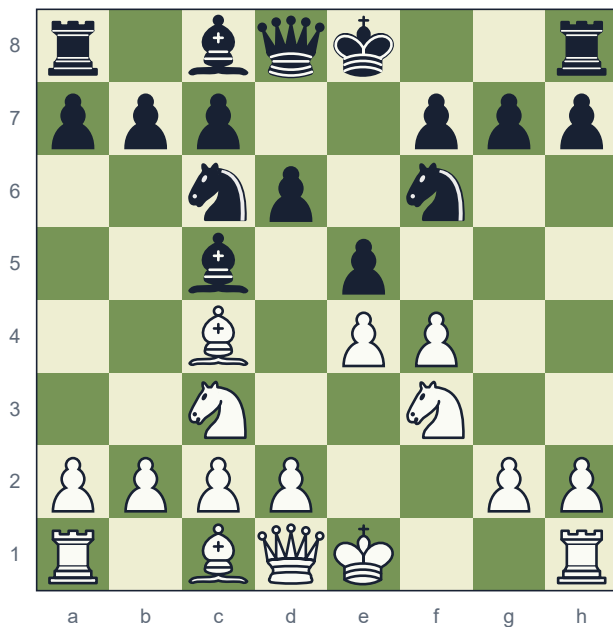
13 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

14 / OPENING RECALL

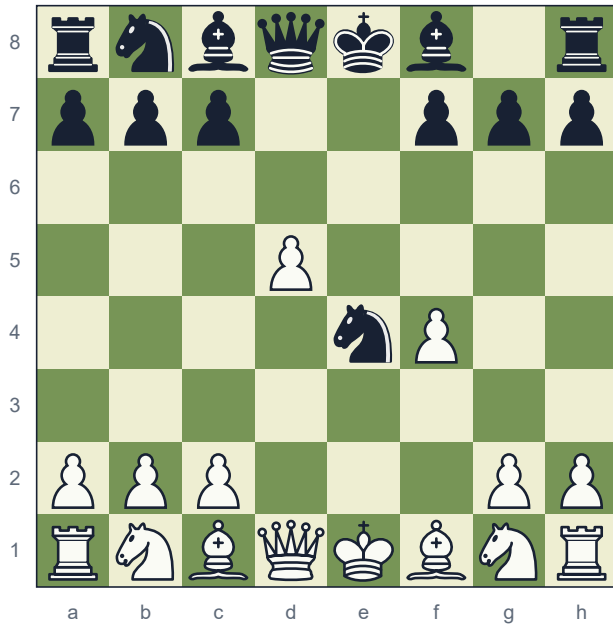
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 15-16



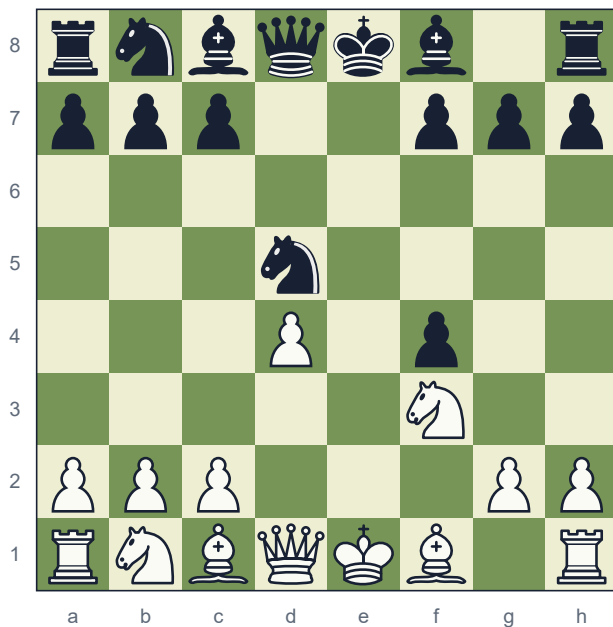
15 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



16 / OPENING RECALL

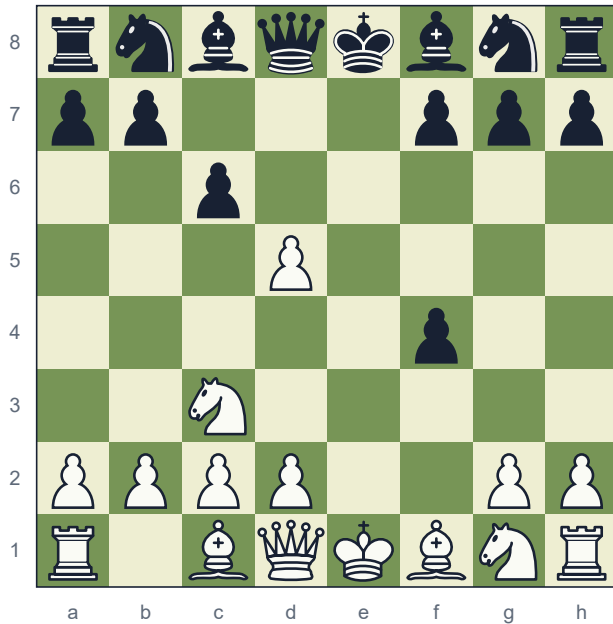
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 17-18



White to move

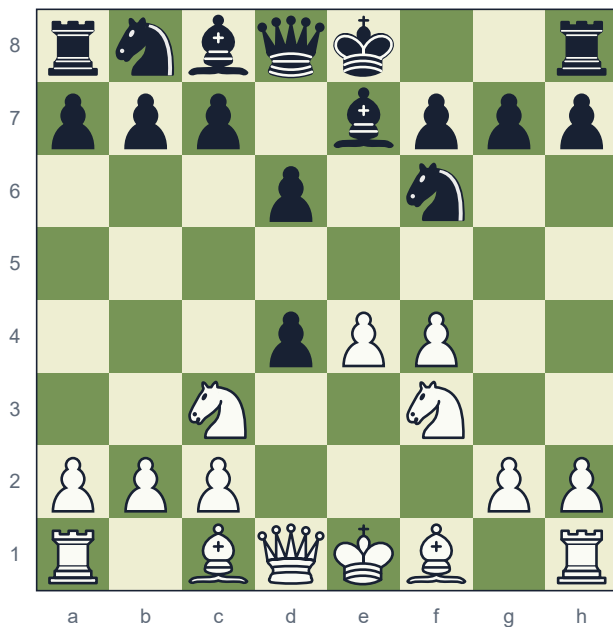
17 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

18 / OPENING RECALL

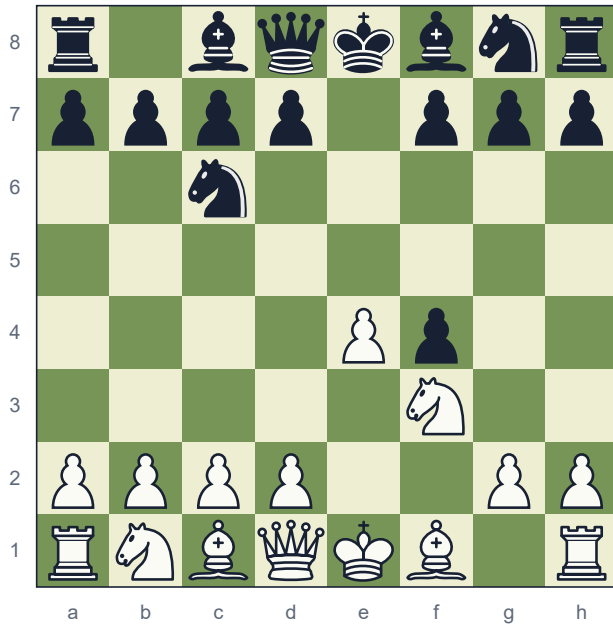
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 19-20



White to move

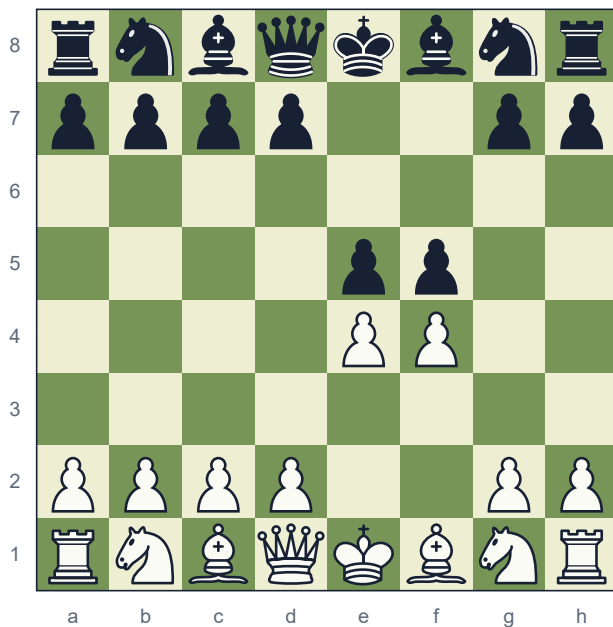
19 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

20 / OPENING RECALL

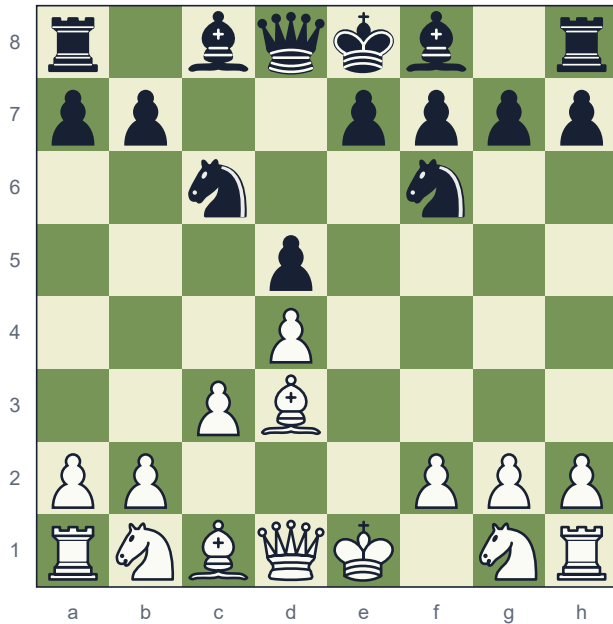
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 21-22



White to move

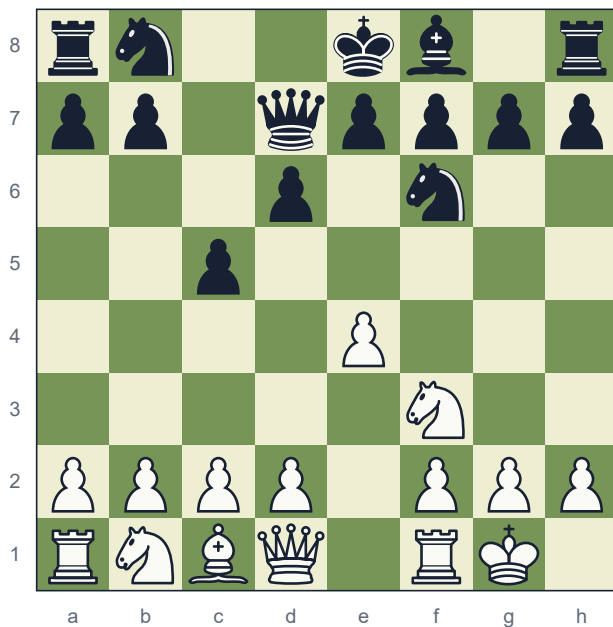
21 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

22 / OPENING RECALL

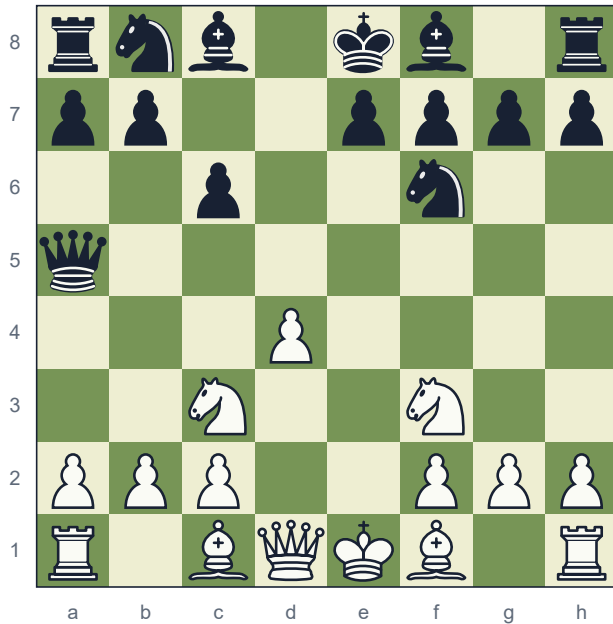
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 23-24



White to move

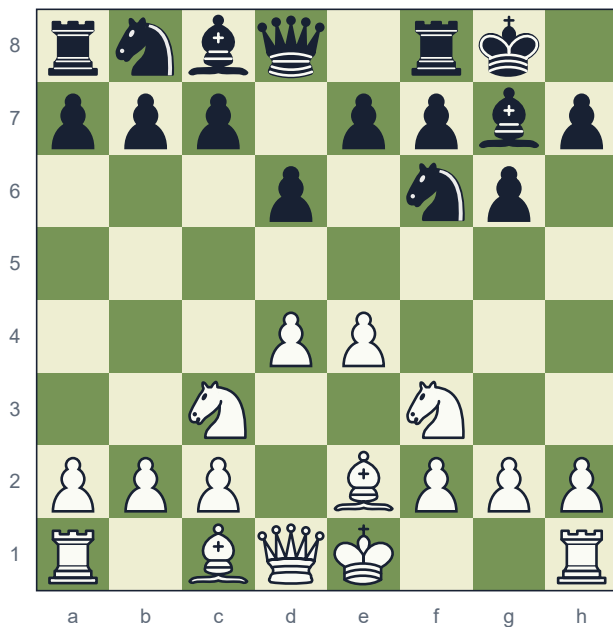
23 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

24 / OPENING RECALL

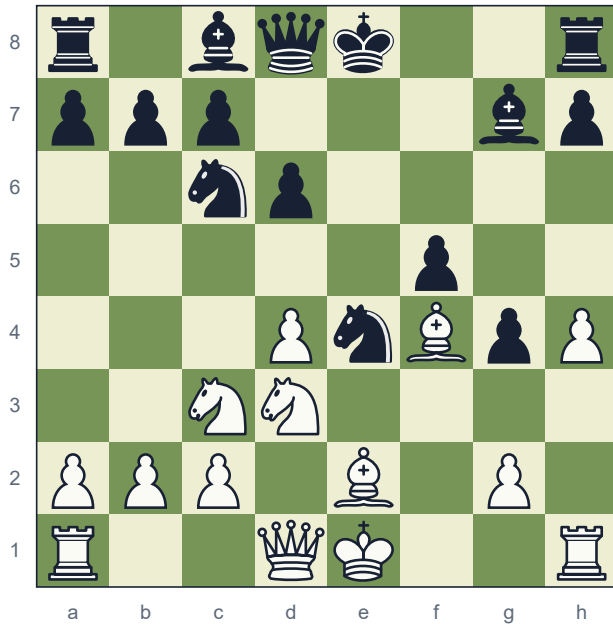
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 25-26



White to move

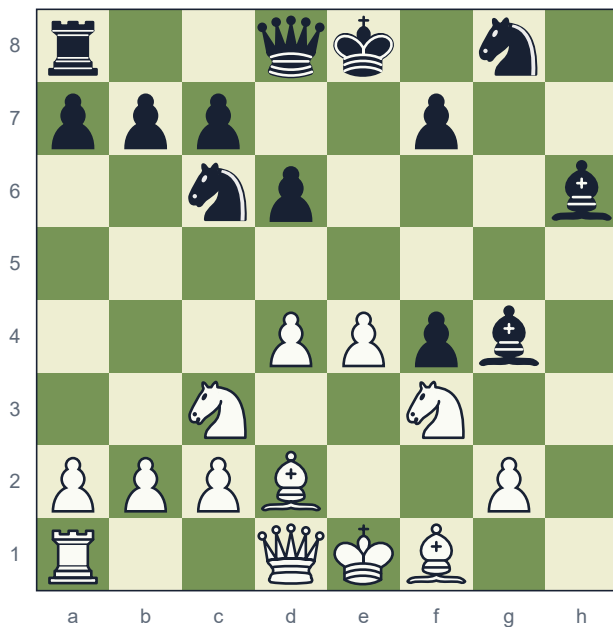
25 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

26 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

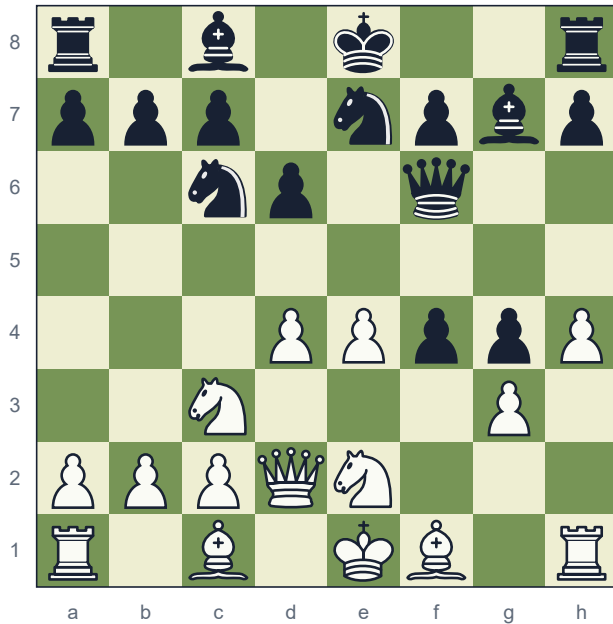
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 27-28



White to move

27 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

28 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

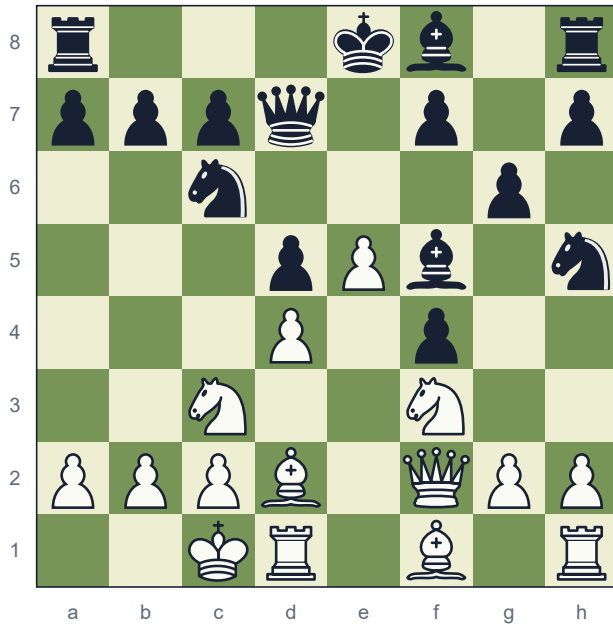
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

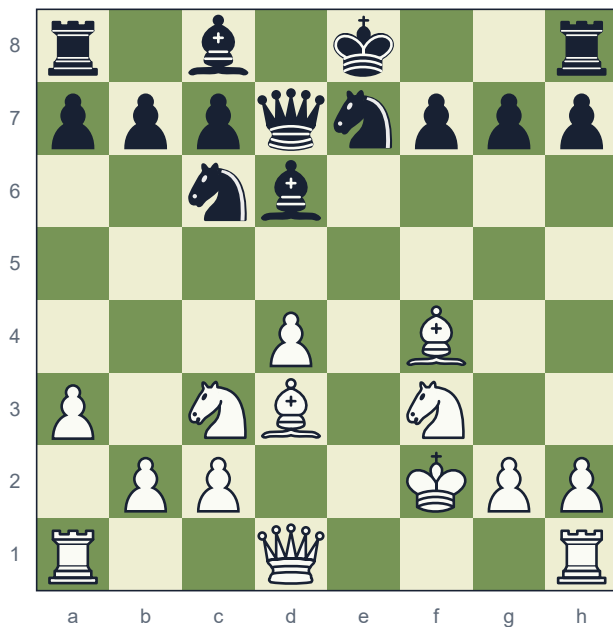
29 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

30 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

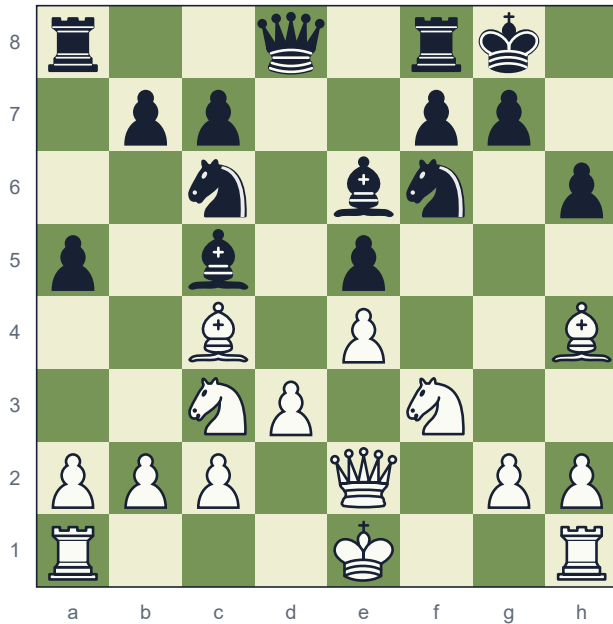
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 31-32



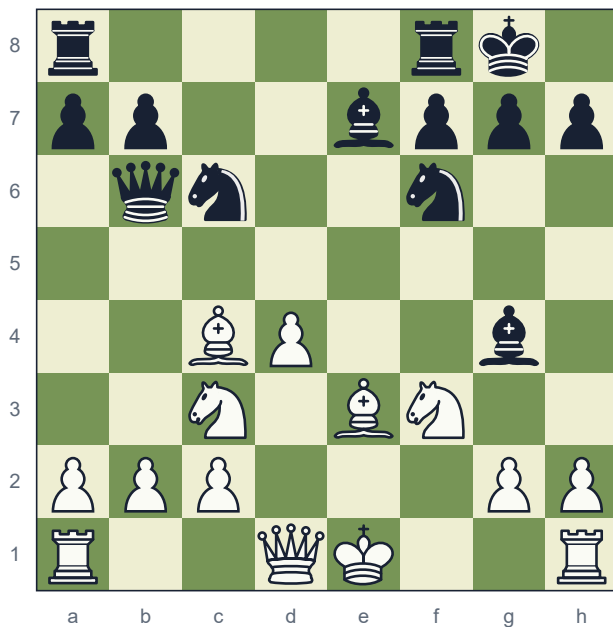
31 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



32 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

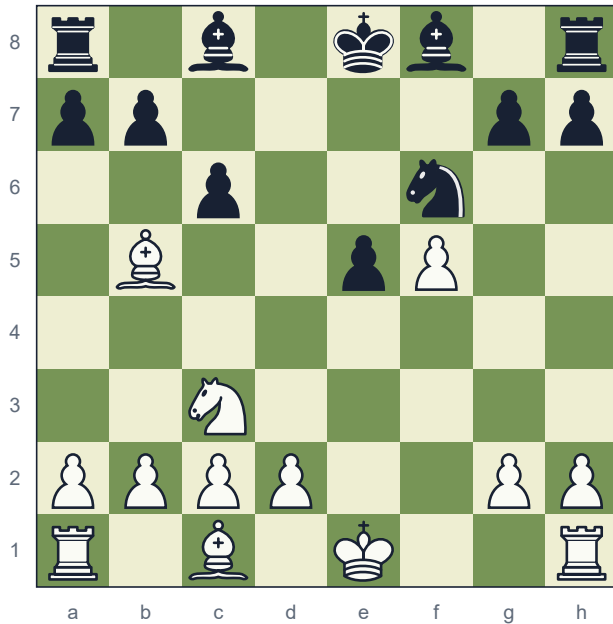
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 33-34



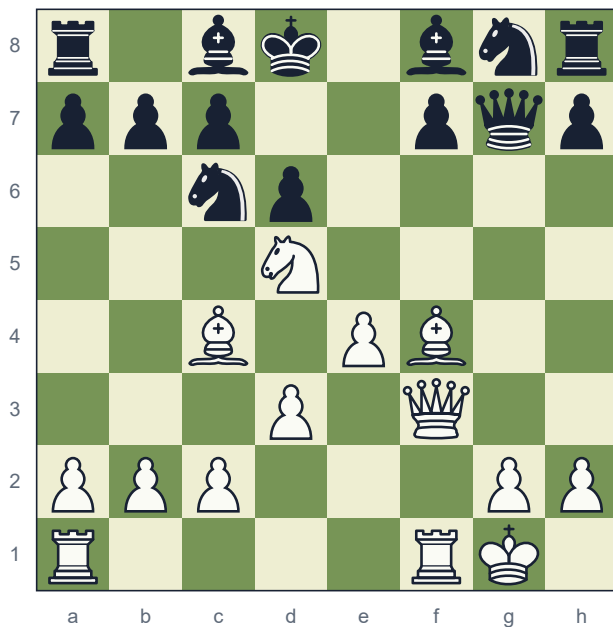
33 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



34 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

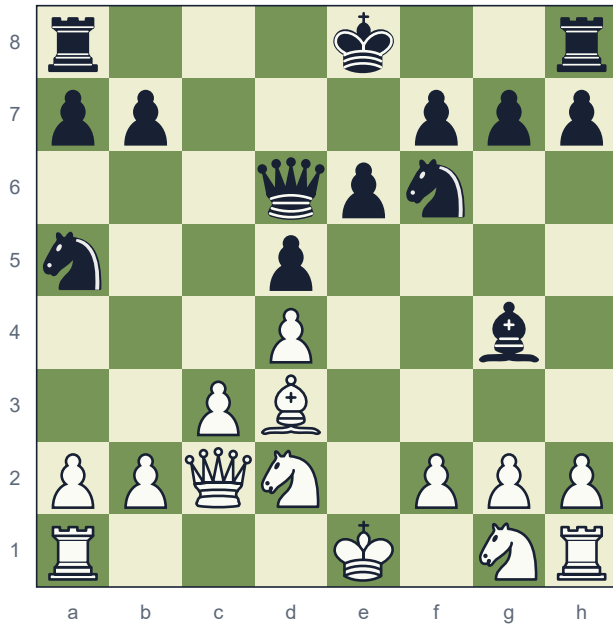
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 35-36



White to move

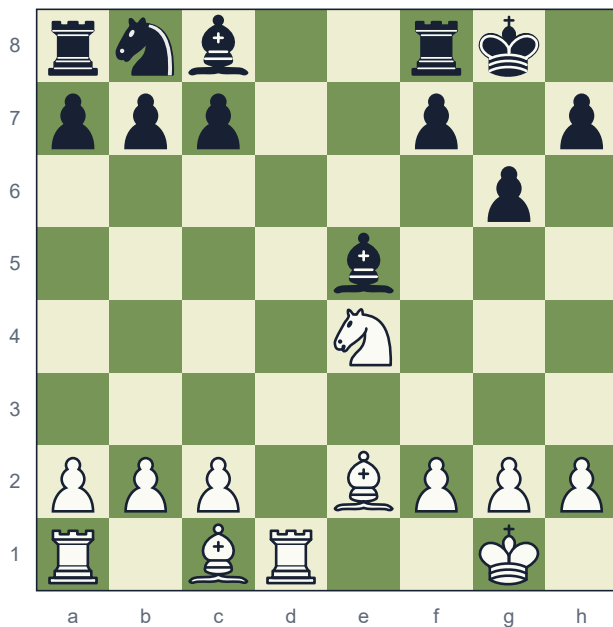
35 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

36 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

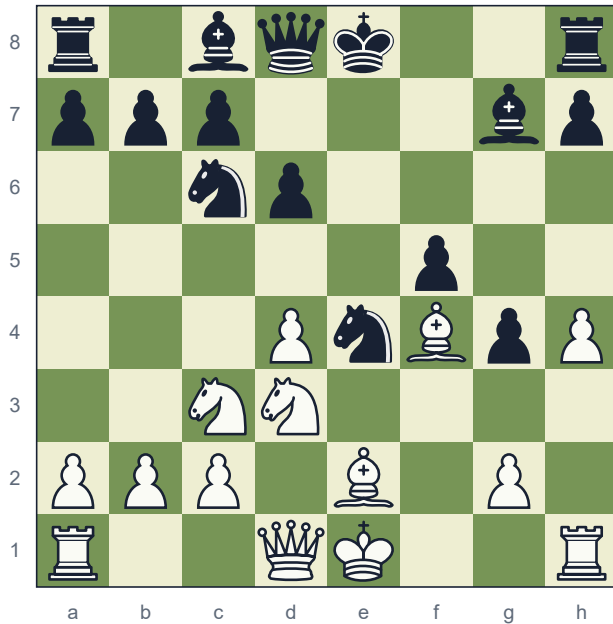
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 37-38



White to move

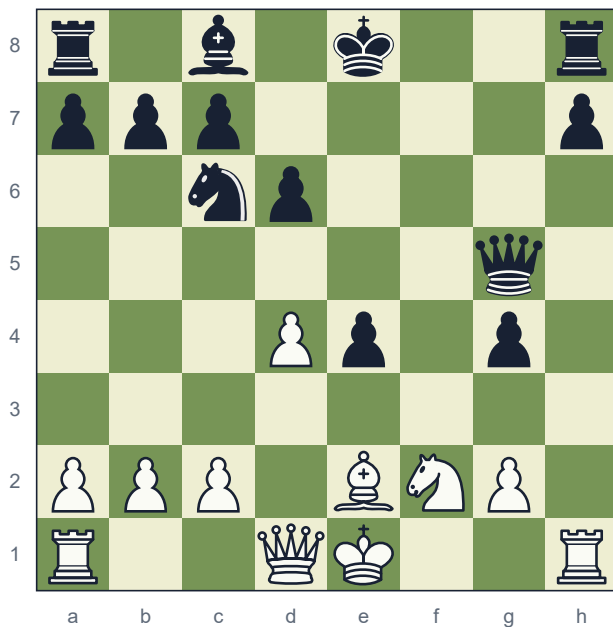
37 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bxg4 with Nxe4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

38 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

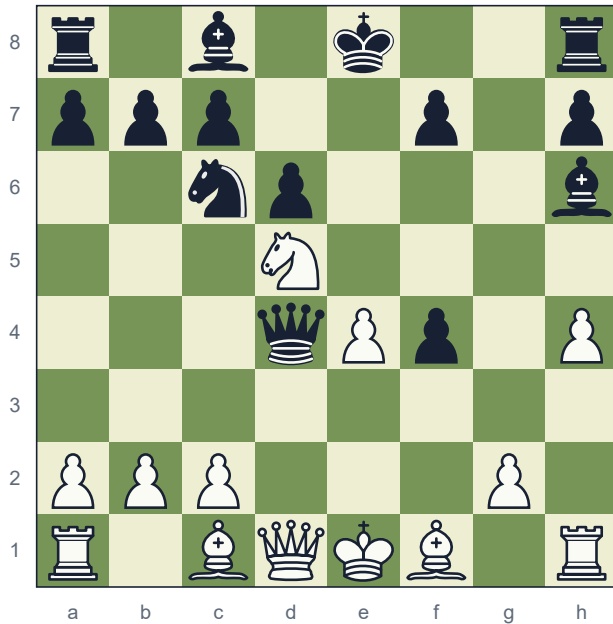
Compare Nxe4 with d5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 39-40



White to move

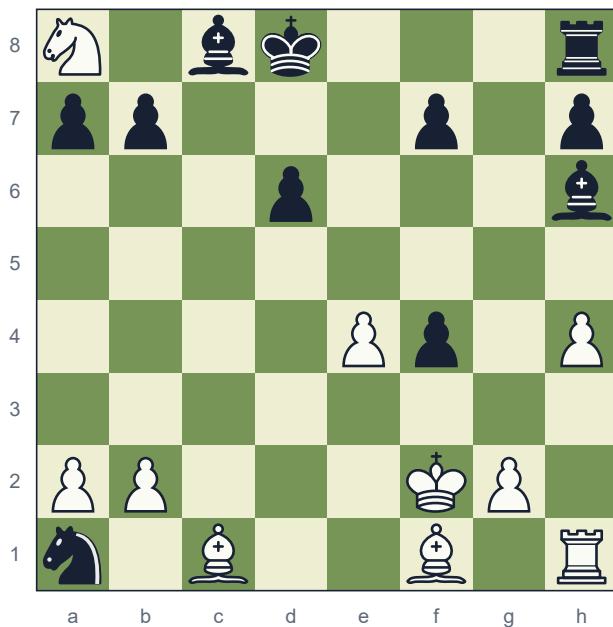
39 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Qxd4 with Nxc7+. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

40 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

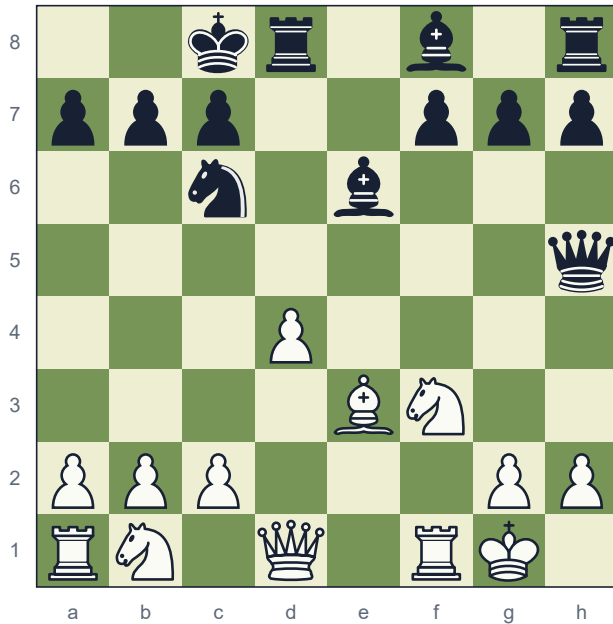
Compare Bd3 with b3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 41-42



White to move

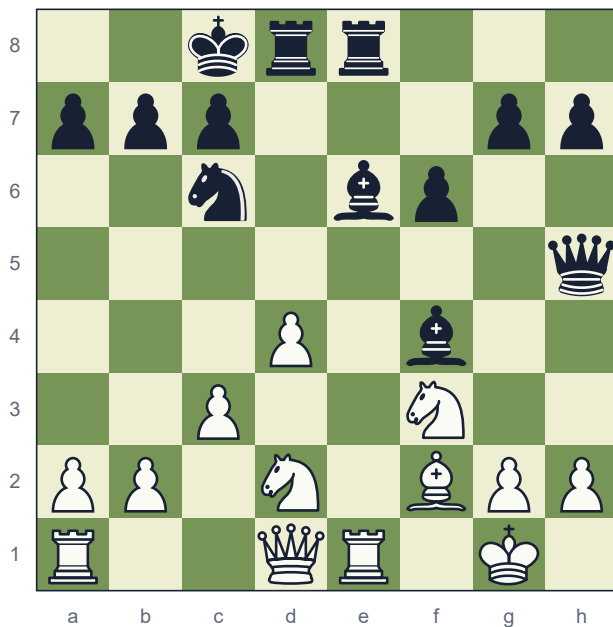
41 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare c3 with Nbd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

42 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nf1 with Bg3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 43-44



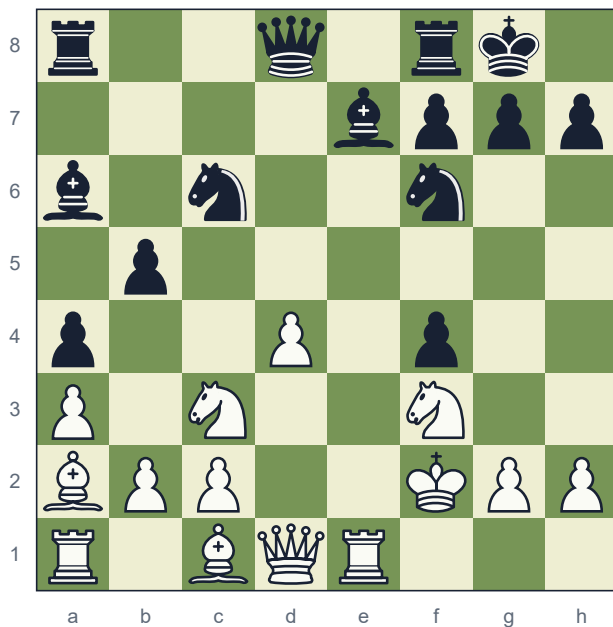
43 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bxf4 with exd5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



44 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

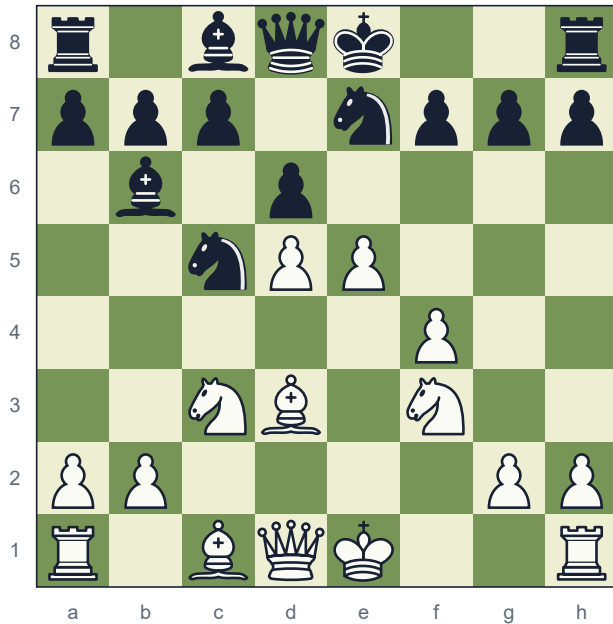
Compare Bxf4 with Kg1. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 45-46



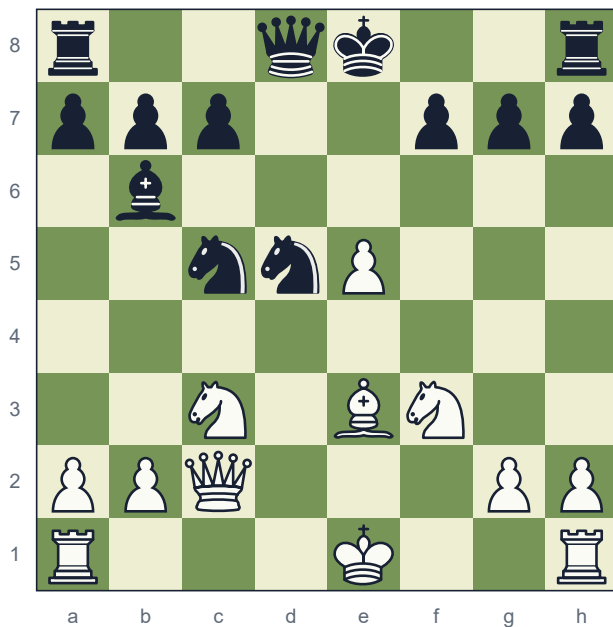
45 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bc4 with Bc2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



46 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

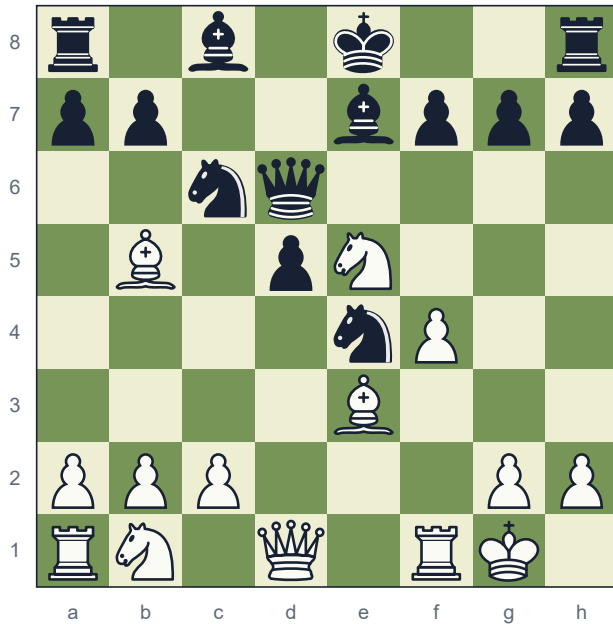
Compare Bxc5 with O-O-O. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 47-48



White to move

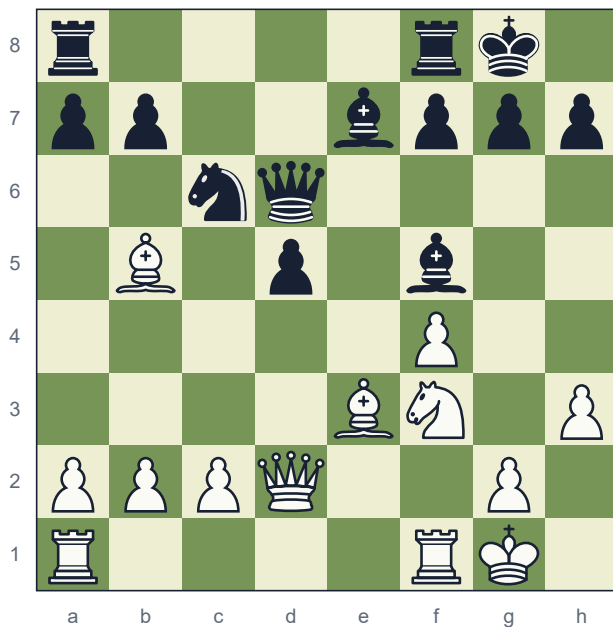
47 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bd3 with Nd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

48 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Rad1 with c3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Answers 1-2

01 / KG-01

Course move: 5. Ne5. Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Ne5 Nf6 6. d4 d6 7. Nd3 Nxe4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7.

02 / KG-02

Course move: 8. Bxf4. The retreat Nd3 keeps the knight protected and allows the bishop to recover f4. Black takes e4, so material recovery alone has not won the opening.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8. Bxf4 Qe7 9. Be2 Nc6 10. Nc3 Nxc3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's knight is active and your king remains central. A speculative attack on f7 can lose time against ...Bg7 and ...O-O.

Answers 3-4

03 / KG-03

Course move: 6. Nxg4. Black attacks Ne5 with the d-pawn, but the knight can capture the advanced g4 pawn while escaping. This concrete resource is stronger than mechanically retreating to d3 in this exact position.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nxg4 Nc6 7. Nc3 Nf6 8. Nxf6+ Qxf6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5.

04 / KG-04

Course move: 5. hxg5. White captures on g5 immediately, testing the supporting pawn chain before building d4. The exact recapture matters because the h-file and rook on h8 can become tactically relevant.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. hxg5 Bg7 6. gxh6 Rxh6 7. Rxh6 Bxh6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may develop with ...Bg7 or use the center. A careless capture can open a rook line against an undeveloped position.

Answers 5-6

05 / KG-07

Course move: 6. Ng1. Black's ...d6 controls e5, so the Kieseritzky knight jump is unavailable. Ng1 is a deliberate retreat preserving the knight after the g-pawn advance.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Ng1 Qf6 7. Nc3 Ne7 8. Nge2 Bh6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Playing Ne5 as if ...d6 were absent simply leaves the knight vulnerable. Black also threatens to complete development while you spend another knight tempo.

06 / KG-08

Course move: 6. Bxf4. Black returns the extra pawn to develop smoothly. White obtains a center and normal pieces, but should not expect a forced attack.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bxf4 O-O 7. Bd3 Nc6 8. a3 Bg4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can challenge the center with ...d5 or ...c5. An undefended e4 pawn can become the target of ...Nxe4 tactics.

Answers 7-8

07 / KG-09

Course move: 6. Bc4. Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bc4 Be6 7. Bxd5 Qxd5 8. O-O Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit.

08 / KG-10

Course move: 6. d4. Nc3 develops while attacking the queen. After her retreat White has gained time, but still needs to complete development and address f4.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. d4 Bd6 7. Bc4 Bf5 8. O-O Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A queen chased once is not trapped. Black can catch up if White spends several moves trying to hunt it.

Answers 9-10

09 / KG-12

Course move: 5. d4. e5 attacks the knight, which heads to h5 to help preserve f4. Black challenges the advanced e-pawn with ...d6.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. d4 d6 6. Qe2 d5 7. Nc3 Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The h5 knight still influences f4 and g3. Do not push g4 without calculating ...fxg3 en passant when legal and the effect on king safety.

10 / KG-13

Course move: 5. Kf1. The bishop reaches h4 with check along the diagonal to e1. Kf1 answers it without pushing more kingside pawns, but permanently gives up castling.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Kf1 c6 6. Nc3 b5 7. Bb3 a5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved.

Answers 11-12

11 / KG-14

Course move: 5. e5. White gains space with e5 and Black places the knight actively. The g4 knight can create threats against e5 or f2; its location is more important than a general developing rule.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. e5 Ng4 6. O-O O-O 7. d4 d5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Bxf7+ is not automatically sound. Black's king may survive while your pieces lack support.

12 / KG-15

Course move: 6. Nc3. Black develops and then hits the center. Nc3 gains a queen tempo, but the exchanges also release Black's pieces.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 Qe6+ 8. Kf2 Nge7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can answer a threat with a check or a capture. Verify the queen's active squares before assuming a free attack.

Answers 13-14

13 / KG-17

Course move: 7. Nc3. White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nc3 Nc6 8. e5 Nd7 9. d5 Ne7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack.

14 / KG-18

Course move: 6. d3. Both sides develop naturally. White keeps the option of a later f-pawn exchange without forcing an immediate central confrontation.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. d3 a5 7. fxe5 dxe5 8. Bg5 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home.

Answers 15-16

15 / KG-19

Course move: 6. Nf3. Black ignores the offered f-pawn and builds an advanced e4 wedge. d3 challenges it directly; exchanges change the position into a development battle.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nf3 c6 7. Be3 cxd5 8. Bb5+ Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's development can be rapid and the king remains on e1. A greedy attempt to keep every extra pawn can allow a central attack.

16 / KG-20

Course move: 6. Bc4. Capturing f4 after ...d5 produces the same type of position as the Modern Defense. The move order differs, but the central exchanges and piece tasks converge.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bc4 Be6 7. Qe2 Bb4+ 8. c3 Be7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

An extra tempo or a different knight square can break a transposition. Compare the actual board before importing a memorized continuation.

Answers 17-18

17 / KG-21

Course move: 5. Nf3. White declines to spend another tempo taking a wing pawn and develops. Black sacrifices or returns material to obtain central and diagonal activity.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Nf3 Be7 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. dxc6 Nxc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Capturing c6 blindly can give Black easy development with ...Nxc6. The point is the resulting activity, not the label countergambit.

18 / KG-22

Course move: 6. Nxd4. Black supports e5 and later exchanges it. White recaptures actively with the knight and gains space without an immediate sacrifice.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Nxd4 O-O 7. Be2 c5 8. Nf3 Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's restrained setup can still strike with ...d5. Do not assume that a passive-looking opening removes tactical obligations.

Answers 19-20

19 / KG-23

Course move: 4. d4. Black may decline for one move and accept later. The position enters accepted-gambit territory with the queen knight already developed.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4. d4 Nf6 5. Qe2 Bd6 6. e5 O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Memorizing only move two misses the transposition. Black may choose ...d5 before trying to defend f4.

20 / KG-24

Course move: 3. exf5. Capturing e5 is not the only way to respond to Black's central pawn action. exf5 exchanges the advanced f-pawn and leaves a concrete position to calculate.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

3. exf5 Qe7 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nc3 Nf6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The exposed kings and open diagonals make routine moves unreliable. A queen check can be more urgent than recovering another pawn.

Answers 21-22

21 / KG-29

Course move: 6. Bf4. The Exchange Caro-Kann bridge creates a clear pawn structure. Bf4 develops the queen bishop before e3 would block it.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bf4 Bg4 7. Qb3 Na5 8. Qc2 e6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange the light-squared bishop or challenge the center. This is a companion starting line, not a complete Caro-Kann repertoire.

22 / KG-30

Course move: 6. Re1. Against ...d6 the check on b5 is a practical bridge. The bishop exchange simplifies development but gives up the bishop pair.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Re1 Nc6 7. c3 e6 8. d4 cxd4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's queen recapture affects d4 and the d-file. This line cannot stand in for all Sicilian variations.

Answers 23-24

23 / KG-31

Course move: 6. Bc4. White gains a developing tempo against the queen and occupies the center. This normal response complements the gambit repertoire when Black immediately attacks e4.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bc4 Bg4 7. h3 Qh5 8. Be2 e6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black often plays ...Bf5 and ...e6. A pin on the c3 knight can affect whether d4 is actually defended.

24 / KG-32

Course move: 6. O-O. White takes the center and develops normally against a fianchetto. This bridge does not require sacrificing the f-pawn or launching an immediate attack.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. O-O e5 7. dxe5 dxe5 8. Nxe5 Nxe4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A large center can become a target. The g7 bishop becomes active when central pawns exchange.

Answers 25-26

25 / KG-01

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

26 / KG-04

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Follow the printed continuation and finish development. Recount material after the whole exchange rather than assuming every pawn contact has an automatic recapture.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may develop with ...Bg7 or use the center. A careless capture can open a rook line against an undeveloped position. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 27-28

27 / KG-07

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e4. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Use the broad center and develop the bishops. The knight must return to play, often through e2 or h3 according to the concrete line.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Playing Ne5 as if ...d6 were absent simply leaves the knight vulnerable. Black also threatens to complete development while you spend another knight tempo. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

28 / KG-09

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king c8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 29-30

29 / KG-12

White to move. White king c1; central-file pawns c2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns f4, d5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Bc4 or Bd3 as appropriate and examine exd6 only after considering the recapture. White must maintain central support while the knight is offside.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The h5 knight still influences f4 and g3. Do not push g4 without calculating ...fxg3 en passant when legal and the effect on king safety. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

30 / KG-15

White to move. White king f2; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and compare queen retreats before choosing a bishop square. A broad center is useful only while it remains defended.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can answer a threat with a check or a capture. Verify the queen's active squares before assuming a free attack. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 31-32

31 / KG-18

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Castle, identify whether d4 is achievable and improve the least active piece. A quiet maneuvering game is a normal outcome of a gambit being declined.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

32 / KG-21

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Stabilize the d-pawn if it is useful, otherwise let material return for development. Check the c-file and queen routes after any dxc6 capture.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Capturing c6 blindly can give Black easy development with ...Nxc6. The point is the resulting activity, not the label countergambit. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 33-34

33 / KG-24

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, d2, f5. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, c6. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Nf3 and choose d4 when safe. Study Black's checks and central captures before treating the extra pawn as secure.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The exposed kings and open diagonals make routine moves unreliable. A queen check can be more urgent than recovering another pawn. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

34 / KG-26

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e4. Black king d8; central-file pawns d6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Calculate forcing play against f7 and e8 before making another sacrifice. Compare attack speed with Black's defensive resources and possible queen exchanges.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black need not cooperate with a famous mating pattern. If the attack stops, White is a piece down rather than merely a pawn down. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 35-36

35 / KG-29

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Finish development and castle. Watch the c-file and choose a useful knight square without obstructing your own pieces.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange the light-squared bishop or challenge the center. This is a companion starting line, not a complete Caro-Kann repertoire. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

36 / KG-32

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2. Black king g8; central-file pawns c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and support e4 before choosing d5 or a kingside expansion. Black's ...c5 and ...e5 are the breaks to monitor.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A large center can become a target. The g7 bishop becomes active when central pawns exchange. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 37-38

37 / KG-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nxe4 (-0.94 from White's perspective), compared with Bxg4 (-1.89 from White's perspective). The knight captures a knight on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nxe4 fxe4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bxg4 O-O 12. Bf3 Nxd4 13. Ne2 Re8 14. c3 Nxe2

38 / KG-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nxe4 (-0.82 from White's perspective), compared with d5 (-1.55 from White's perspective). The knight captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nxe4 Qg6 16. Ng3 Bd7 17. Qd3 O-O-O 18. Qxg6 hxg6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. d5 Ne5 16. Nxe4 Qg6 17. Ng3 h5 18. Qd4 h4

Answers 39-40

39 / KG-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Nxc7+ (+0.31 from White's perspective), compared with Qxd4 (+0.32 from White's perspective). The knight captures a pawn on c7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nxc7+ Kd8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Qxd4 Nxd4 12. Nxc7+ Kd8 13. Nxa8 Nxc2+ 14. Kf2 Nxa1

40 / KG-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Bd3 (+0.04 from White's perspective), compared with b3 (-0.81 from White's perspective). Places the bishop on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Bd3 Rg8 16. Bd2 Rg3 17. Bb5 Nc2 18. Rc1 Ne3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. b3 Nc2 16. Bb2 Rg8 17. Bf6+ Kd7 18. Bb5+ Ke6

Answers 41-42

41 / KG-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nbd2 (-0.64 from White's perspective), compared with c3 (-0.68 from White's perspective). Develops the queen knight while leaving the c-pawn free. The knight supports e4 and may seek c4 or a route through f1.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nbd2 Bd6 12. Ne4 Be7 13. c3 Rhe8 14. Ng3 Qg6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. c3 f6 12. Re1 Bd6 13. Nbd2 Rhe8 14. Bf2 g5

42 / KG-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nf1 (-0.63 from White's perspective), compared with Bg3 (-0.72 from White's perspective). Places the knight on f1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nf1 Bd5 16. Rxe8 Rxe8 17. Ng3 Bxg3 18. hxg3 Nd8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Bg3 Bh6

Answers 43-44

43 / KG-LAB-04

The finite search prefers exd5 (+0.17 from White's perspective), compared with Bxf4 (+0.02 from White's perspective). The pawn captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. exd5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bxf4 Nf6 12. exd5 O-O 13. dxc6 Nxc6 14. Nxb5 Na7

44 / KG-LAB-04

The finite search prefers Bxf4 (+0.53 from White's perspective), compared with Kg1 (+0.00 from White's perspective). The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Bxf4 b4 16. Ne4 bxa3 17. bxa3 Bxa3 18. Bb1 Bb2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Kg1 Bd6 16. Ne5 Qb6 17. Bxf4 Qxd4+ 18. Qxd4 Nxd4

Answers 45-46

45 / KG-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Bc2 (+0.51 from White's perspective), compared with Bc4 (+0.12 from White's perspective). Places the bishop on c2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Bc2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bc4 O-O 12. Be3 c6 13. dxc6 Nxc6 14. Qxd6 Qxd6

46 / KG-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Bxc5 (+0.10 from White's perspective), compared with O-O-O (+0.07 from White's perspective). The bishop captures a knight on c5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Bxc5 Bxc5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. O-O-O Nxe3 16. Rxd8+ Rxd8 17. Qe2 O-O 18. Kb1 Ne6

Answers 47-48

47 / KG-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Nd2 (+0.03 from White's perspective), compared with Bd3 (-0.25 from White's perspective). Places the knight on d2, attacking knight on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nd2 Nxd2 12. Qxd2 O-O 13. Nf3 Bf5 14. c3 Be4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bd3 Nxe5

48 / KG-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Rad1 (+0.13 from White's perspective), compared with c3 (+0.04 from White's perspective). Places the rook on d1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Rad1 Qg6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. c3 h6 16. Rad1 Be4 17. Bd3 Qe6 18. Nd4 Nxd4